

Non-Examples of an Ikeda Classroom

A classroom moves away from Daisaku Ikeda's philosophy when it diminishes dignity, substitutes conformity for dialogue, separates knowledge from humane purpose or mistakes comfort for happiness.

Prepared by Peter Bjork, M.Ed., DePaul University - College of Education - PhD in Value-Creating Education for Global Citizens

SYNTHESIS Ikeda did not publish a checklist of classroom "non-examples." These contrasts are reasoned implications of his stated commitments to teacher-student trust, dialogue, value creation, global citizenship and knowledge directed toward happiness and peace.

THE FOUR-POINT DIAGNOSTIC COMPASS

DIGNITY

Is each learner treated as capable of growth—not as a score, problem or follower?

DIALOGUE

Can students question, dissent, listen and revise without coercion?

WISDOM

Is rigorous knowledge joined to judgment, responsibility and consequence?

CONTRIBUTION

Does learning enlarge agency and benefit rather than status alone?



1 THE INDOCTRINATION CLASSROOM

Belief is prescribed; inquiry is treated as disloyalty.

- Students must praise Ikeda, Buddhism or the institution.
- Approved conclusions precede the evidence.
- Religious participation affects belonging or success.

Why misaligned: Ikeda stated that education does not exist for religion and opposed sectarian schooling.

Better shift: Study philosophies critically; protect freedom of conscience; assess reasoning, not profession of belief.



2 THE TEACHER ON A THRONE

Authority outranks truth; error invites shame.

- The teacher controls every interpretation.
- Students comply publicly and disengage privately.
- Mistakes become evidence of fixed ability.

Why misaligned: Ikeda described teachers as partners in discovery and placed trust at the center of education.

Better shift: Keep adult responsibility and subject expertise while modeling fallibility, listening and mutual growth.



3 THE EXAMINATION FACTORY

Scores, rank and credentials become the purpose.

- Recall crowds out explanation and application.
- Competition defines human worth.
- No one asks what the knowledge enables.

Why misaligned: Knowledge is indispensable, but Ikeda argued that wisdom must direct it toward happiness and peace.

Better shift: Use tests diagnostically; require mastery, reasoning, transfer and reflection on consequence.



4 THE CONTENT-FREE "STUDENT-CENTERED" ROOM

Choice replaces teaching; activity replaces learning.

- The teacher withholds necessary explanation.
- Projects are engaging but conceptually thin.
- Students rehearse misconceptions unaided.

Why misaligned: Belief in potential demands serious intellectual support, not adult absence.

Better shift: Model difficult knowledge explicitly, then expand student agency through inquiry and application.

When humane language hides inhumane practice

Some classrooms appear progressive, caring or globally minded while still suppressing difference, lowering expectations or avoiding responsibility.



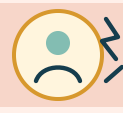
5 THE FORCED-CONSENSUS CIRCLE

Everyone may speak—provided they reach the approved view.

- Dissent is labeled negative or uncompassionate.
- Listening is performative.
- Harmony matters more than accuracy.

Why misaligned: Ikeda's global citizen needs courage to encounter difference and grow from it.

Better shift: Require evidence and fair listening; allow principled disagreement and visible revision without forced closure.



6 HAPPINESS AS COMFORT

Challenge and candid feedback are removed to protect feelings.

- Productive struggle is treated as harm.
- Standards fall quietly for selected students.
- Difficult realities are covered with optimism.

Why misaligned: Value-creating happiness is the capacity to make meaning and benefit amid difficulty—not permanent ease.

Better shift: Combine psychological safety with ambitious work, specific support and honest feedback.



7 COMPASSION WITHOUT COURAGE

Harm is excused because the person causing it is struggling.

- Victims carry the burden of “understanding.”
- Boundaries disappear.
- Restorative language replaces accountability.

Why misaligned: Ikeda links compassion with courageous engagement; dignity applies to everyone affected.

Better shift: Stop harm, establish facts, hear impact, require repair and support a responsible return.



8 CHARITY THEATRE AND GLOBAL TOURISM

Students collect experiences, gratitude or publicity—not understanding.

- Communities become objects of service.
- Flags and food replace history and power.
- The project ends when the photograph is taken.

Why misaligned: Global citizenship requires interdependence, empathy and action—not paternalism or cultural consumption.

Better shift: Co-design work with communities; examine structural causes; return useful products and sustain relationships.

CORRECT THE HIDDEN SUBSTITUTION

Conformity
“We all agree.”



Dialogue
“We understand the disagreement and its evidence.”

Comfort
“Nothing should feel difficult.”



Happiness
“I can create value through difficulty.”

Sentiment
“We care about the issue.”



Contribution
“Our knowledge enables a responsible action.”

OTHER WARNING SIGNS

- **Personality grading:** rewarding extroversion, agreeableness or professed virtue.
- **Public shame:** defining a learner by one error or incident.
- **False collaboration:** confident students work while others copy.
- **Inspiration without accuracy:** uplifting conclusions resting on weak facts.
- **Teacher martyrdom:** boundaryless availability treated as proof of care.

Distinguish the tool from its use

A lecture, test, competition or consequence is not inherently anti-Ikeda. Ask what purpose it serves, how power is exercised and what students become able to do.

NOT AUTOMATICALLY NON-EXAMPLES

LECTURE

Can align: clear explanation equips later inquiry.

Misaligns: authority silences questions or treats knowledge as an end.

TEST

Can align: reveals mastery and guides feedback.

Misaligns: rank defines worth or recall crowds out understanding.

COMPETITION

Can align: challenge promotes disciplined excellence.

Misaligns: winning requires another person's diminishment.

FIRM BOUNDARY

Can align: protects dignity, truth and safety.

Misaligns: control, fear or humiliation becomes the method.

WALK-THROUGH: RED FLAG → BETTER QUESTION

What you observe	Ask next
Students repeat the teacher's moral conclusion.	What evidence could challenge it? Are dissenting interpretations genuinely possible?
The room is busy, collaborative and cheerful.	What exact disciplinary knowledge is each student gaining and demonstrating?
A discussion reaches quick agreement.	Were important differences explored, represented fairly and allowed to remain?
The teacher is exceptionally warm and available.	Are expectations, boundaries and support equitable and sustainable?
Students complete a service or global project.	Who defined the need? What was useful to the community? What relationship continues?
Discipline is called "restorative."	Was harm stopped, impact heard, responsibility accepted and repair completed?
Results and university destinations are impressive.	Who is unseen or excluded? Can students use knowledge wisely beyond the credential?

THREE-STEP INTERPRETATION

1 · NOTICE
Describe behavior without guessing intent.



2 · TEST
Check dignity, dialogue, wisdom and contribution.



3 · SHIFT
Change the structure—not merely the slogan.

One observation is not a verdict. Look for repeated patterns, student experience and the distribution of voice, challenge and consequence.

SIX-SENTENCE DIAGNOSTIC

- Students principally **obey** rather than inquire.
- They **repeat** rather than understand.
- They **agree** rather than encounter difference.
- They **perform virtue** rather than create value.
- They **acquire status** rather than contribute.
- They **avoid difficulty** rather than transform through it.

USE WITH A TEAM

Choose one recurring classroom routine. Name the non-example risk it could drift toward. Then redesign one concrete feature: the question, participation structure, assessment evidence, consequence or community relationship.

Routine to examine:

SOURCE BASIS

[1] D. Ikeda, "Thoughts on Education for Global Citizenship," Teachers College, 1996. daisakuikeda.org/.../lect-08

[2] "Soka Education in Practice": teacher–student trust, belief and life-to-life interaction. daisakuikeda.org/.../edu-04

[3] Ikeda Center, "The Four Aspects of Daisaku Ikeda's Education Philosophy": dialogue, global citizenship, value creation and creative coexistence. ikedacenter.org/resources/...

[4] J. Goulah & R. Kartha, "Wisdom and Contemplative Effort in Ikeda Daisaku's Philosophy of Human Education," 2026: secular human education, mutual growth and knowledge–wisdom distinction. doi:10.25035/jche.03.02.09

Interpretive limit: these non-examples are analytical contrasts, not quotations or an official Soka evaluation instrument. Context, implementation and student experience determine whether a practice embodies or contradicts the philosophy.